

to the oncology challenge given the rising cancer burden in India?

A: We haven't cured cancer yet. So, there is always room for more innovation. While there has been strong progress globally, the challenge remains in bringing these innovations to India quickly. Historically, a drug launched in the US would take several years to reach Indian patients, which was a gap we are now trying to close.

We are working hard to accelerate this process. In FY25, we secured nine regulatory approvals, helping us address patient needs. We can and must do even better, and this is a shared goal across the industry, to ensure that Indian patients get faster access to global innovations.

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Q: Could you elaborate on the oncology pipeline AstraZeneca has built?

A: There are broadly two key approaches to treating cancer: destroying cancer cells directly and activating the immune system to do so. We have a strong portfolio addressing both.

Another major focus is antibody-drug conjugates, where we have one of the industry's leading portfolios. Due to their precision, these treatments have shown great promise. We are also developing T-cell engagers and other new modalities.

Almost 90% of our portfolio is precision medicine, where treatments are targeted to patients most likely to benefit. Traditional chemotherapy used a one-size-fits-all approach, which caused severe side effects and limited improvements. Antibody-drug conjugates represent a shift towards precision medicine, and much of our current effort focuses on bringing these advances to oncology care.

**Q: Rare diseases are another critical area for AstraZeneca. How do you see this market evolving in India?**

A: Our purpose is to address needs, and rare diseases have long been underserved. This led to acquisition of Alexion, a leading rare disease company, in 2021. A key aim of that acquisition was to bring these therapies to emerging markets, including India.

Recently, we also launched Eculizumab, a well-recognised therapy in rare diseases. What is rare in other countries may not be so rare in India due to the large population. Some diseases may affect 30,000–40,000 patients here compared to only hundreds elsewhere.

The National Policy for Rare Diseases is a positive step, and we hope to contribute to such initiatives further.

Q: What are your growth drivers for the next three to five years? Are you planning organic or inorganic expansion?

A: We plan to introduce around 20 new medicines globally by 2030. Many of these will reach India over time depending on clinical progress.

Three major therapy areas will drive growth: oncology; biopharmaceuticals covering cardiovascular, renal, respiratory, and vaccines; and rare diseases, where we are investing for the long term. These three pillars will define our growth path over the next few years.

Q: Indian companies are focusing on bio-